

Letter of Support for Professor Lei Zou's Teaching Award Nomination

Dear Members of the Selection Committee,

I support Dr. Lei Zou's nomination for the college-level teaching award with 200 percent confidence. I believe many professors in the college deserve recognition for teaching. But from my own experience, Dr. Zou is a particularly deserving candidate. I have taken at least four courses or instructional experiences with him, including GEODATABASES, FRONTIERS IN GISCIENCE, DIRECTED STUDIES, and RESEARCH. He is also my advisor, and we meet almost every week for one-on-one research and academic guidance. Because I have learned from him in classrooms, directed study, research, and advising, I believe I have enough experience to speak honestly about his teaching ability, teaching style, and influence on students.

I support him not because he is a perfect teacher, but because he is an imperfect teacher who keeps becoming better. His spoken communication is very clear and close to excellent, but I do not need to pretend that any teacher is a perfect 100. He is not an extremely extroverted person. I am very outgoing myself, and for a long time I imagined that the best teacher must also be naturally expressive, energetic, and able to win attention immediately. Dr. Zou changed that idea for me. His knowledge is broad, and his fundamentals are strong. But this is also the AI era. I can use large language models, the internet, and online resources to obtain almost any written knowledge at any time. No human teacher is a machine, and no teacher can remember everything. What matters more is what a teacher shows students about how to think, how to work, and how to improve. Even in his advising of me, Dr. Zou is not perfect, and I do not want him to be presented that way. I am a demanding student who often brings cross-disciplinary AI ideas into geography and GIScience research, so the expectations I place on myself and on my advisor are extremely high. I cannot give myself 100 points, and I cannot give my advisor 100 points. Only God can receive 100 points.

So why do I still recommend Dr. Zou so strongly? Because in him, I saw for the first time a teacher who trains and polishes himself with the seriousness of a Korean girl group trainee. I like Korean girl groups because their performances are built from almost obsessive practice: every movement, every expression, every transition, and every moment on stage is refined until the final performance becomes professional and fascinating. If I had to describe Dr. Zou, I would call him an *academic idol*: someone who holds himself to a high standard and keeps polishing the craft of teaching. No one is born knowing how to become a faculty member. No one is born knowing how to teach a good course. What matters is training, self-demand, and the willingness to improve. In Dr. Zou's classes, I have seen someone who is not naturally showy, and who is more research-oriented by nature, work hard to become a stronger teacher. I notice the details of his slides, the design of his examples, the structure of his lectures, and even the carefully placed jokes that help students stay engaged. I once thought I might teach better than him because I am more outgoing and more visibly passionate. But after leading lab sessions myself, I understood something important: professional training, strict self-discipline, and the ability to do well in an area that is not naturally easy are exactly what deserve respect.

I do not want to compare Dr. Zou with other faculty members. I can only speak from my 26 years of life and from my own academic experience. He is one of the rare people I have met who truly wants to make teaching good. Many students now do not attend courses seriously because they feel course content is disconnected from reality. AI is also becoming stronger, and in my personal view, much course content can now be learned from AI more conveniently and at any time. Under these conditions, teachers like Dr. Zou become especially valuable. What he teaches me is not simply written knowledge that I could get by talking with ChatGPT. He teaches the ability to handle things one is not naturally good at, a high level of professional commitment, and a life philosophy that refuses to treat work as something to be done perfunctorily. He also teaches through his logic. When I follow the way he thinks, I learn far more than I expected. In an academic environment where publication pressure is growing, fewer teachers are willing to invest this much care in teaching. His courses are worth attending, just as people are willing to pay for K-pop performances because they value the professionalism, atmosphere, and spirit behind the stage. I am willing to experience Dr. Zou's imperfections, to learn from his character, and to become his friend and student. I believe students who take his courses can gain more confidence, because he is showing us how to do something well.

In my mind, Dr. Zou is already a recipient of this award, regardless of the final result. If I become a faculty member in the future, I hope I can become a teacher like him: someone with real teaching ability, someone willing to iterate, and someone strict with myself. He is not perfect, but he is one of the best partners, mentors, and friends I have had at Texas A&M. He is one of the most important reasons I still feel that I belong on campus and want to keep growing here. If my letter can help, I offer my strongest support. Effort needs to be seen. Professionalism needs to be seen. Dr. Zou's teaching deserves to be seen.

Sincerely,

Yifan Yang
Ph.D. Student
Department of Geography
Texas A&M University